

negative impact on your net wealth (illegal drugs cost Canada \$8.2 billion a year). Any family that has major problems with alcohol or drugs is going to suffer.

Gambling

According to a 2011 Statistics Canada report, more than 70 percent of Canadians with an after-tax income of \$40,000 or more participate in at least one gambling activity. Most common are government lotteries, with other lotteries and raffles in second place, followed by casinos, slot machines, video lottery terminals and bingos. Fortunately, the average annual household expenditure on gambling tends to be under \$500, which means the majority of Canadians are keeping themselves in check. But if your partner has an addiction to gambling, you'll know it—because, apart from the severe emotional toll, your finances are going to take a massive hit. Again, I advise giving your partner three chances to curb his or her behavior and seek help. But after that, you've got to get away.

Debt

Bad money choices of all other kinds—even when not related to addictions—are pernicious and destructive. No matter how much you love your partner, if he or she is sinking deeper and deeper into debt, it's time to call it quits. You must protect your family dynasty, even if it pits you against your partner. Unfortunately, if you've tried three times and haven't succeeded in eliciting lasting change, you've got no other choice.

Here's something interesting: on my list of deal breakers, you may notice that infidelity didn't make the list. That's because it is easier to address than financial problems. Don't get me wrong: it is still indescribably difficult to reestablish trust after an affair. But unless the infidelity is indicative of a more deeply ingrained addictive behavior, it is often something a couple can work through.

If you or your partner has cheated, it's time to ask some hard questions. First: Why'd you do it? Second: Can you fix it? Hopefully,